

Why I Cannot Prove Mine or Discard Yours: Identity, Other Minds, and Irreparable Suffering in Experiential Empiricism

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Abstract

Personal persistence and other minds share an epistemic structure: present experience establishes its occurrence, while assigning another occurrence to the same or a different subject requires an additional inference. Experiential Empiricism (EE) makes this symmetry explicit without erasing the concrete distinction between directly felt suffering and another person's suffering reports. The present experiential card can contain an entire autobiography without establishing an owner who persists through the represented history. Experiential totality must include any other experiencing that exists, but neither totality nor uncertainty about personal boundaries establishes one universal subject or a shared metaphysical container. Applied to uploading, the distinction separates comparative preservation of ordinary continuity from proof that a particular experiencer survives. Applied to ethics, it shows why successors, compensation, memory alteration, and prior or subsequent consent cannot cancel a suffering occurrence. Ulysses pacts expose the further error of granting an earlier identity model unconditional authority over a presently suffering subject. The paper distinguishes this argument against cancellation from the Hedonic Core Framework's additional prohibition on suffering spikes, and identifies the externalist catastrophe at its smallest scale: one concrete sufferer subordinated to an abstraction about who owns, benefits from, or will eventually redeem the suffering.

Keywords: Experiential Empiricism, personal identity, other minds, temporal experience, mind uploading, Ulysses contracts, suffering spikes, experiential totality, Reality Repair Theory, Hedonic Core Framework

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1. The certainty of experience is not the certainty of its owner

Experiential Empiricism begins with $\exists E$: experience is. Denial, doubt, explanation, and the demand for proof are themselves experiential occurrences. This foundation does not require a separate owner to establish it. Nor does it require an independently existing temporal sequence through which an owner travels. EE’s stronger claim is that anything with actual content is experiential: the proposed external entity, when characterized rather than merely labeled, supplies experiential attributes. The *Experientia Est* challenge asks for one thing that is not experience; the proposed exception never acquires non-experiential content (Sergeant, *Experientia Est*).

This foundation is frequently translated into “I experience.” That translation introduces something the foundation did not require. The occurrence is given. An enduring “I,” its boundaries, and its ownership of other occurrences are further claims. Ordinary speech compresses these together because ordinary practical life rarely demands that they be separated. A foundational inquiry cannot permit the compression to decide the question in advance. The certainty that pain occurs does not automatically establish an entity that owned yesterday’s pain and will own tomorrow’s relief.

The resulting problem is usually divided into separate topics. Personal identity asks whether I persist.

Other minds asks whether someone else experiences. Temporal ontology asks whether the represented past and future exist independently of their present representation. Ethics asks whose suffering counts. The division conceals their dependence on a common operation: assigning experiential occurrences to subjects whose unity, separation, and persistence have not inherited the occurrence's self-establishing status. This paper examines that operation and its consequences. Its purpose is not to replace the persistent ego with another hidden entity. It is to establish what remains concrete when the ownership claim no longer carries unearned certainty.

2. What “mine” means without an enduring owner

The distinction between my pain and yours is concrete. I feel this pain directly. I encounter your pain through speech, behavior, expression, resistance, and other indications. Hearing a report of agony does not ordinarily include undergoing that agony. This asymmetry is part of experiential structure, not an illusion produced by failing to understand totality. It explains why consuming an organism does not automatically include feeling whatever the organism feels. The absence of shared feeling, however, does not establish the absence of feeling on the organism's side, and supplies no exemption from moral scrutiny.

“Mine” can therefore retain a local meaning. It identifies directly felt bodily sensation, agency, autobiographical familiarity, or another feature of the occurrence. Those features need not be assigned to a persistent metaphysical possessor in order to be distinguished. Removing that possessor does not make a headache and a report of someone else's headache phenomenally identical. It prevents the local distinction from being promoted without argument into a durable property boundary dividing all experience into what an established owner possesses and what exists elsewhere.

The distinction also prevents an overcorrection in the opposite direction. Failure to establish separate enduring owners does not prove one shared owner. Directly felt pain does not become everyone's pain merely because a permanent self cannot be demonstrated. The appropriate result is more precise: the phenomenal distinction is given; the account of permanent ownership is not. Neither a private soul nor a universal consciousness can claim the occurrence's certainty merely by offering a story about who has it.

This matters ethically because being directly felt is not a credential that reported suffering must acquire before it counts. Your speech and behavior are already encountered experiential content. Their status does not depend on my first duplicating your alleged pain. EE's epistemic honesty distinguishes those encountered patterns from proof of another phenomenal occurrence, while its practical response protects against false dismissal of a genuine sufferer (Sergent, *Epistemic Honesty*). The distinction between felt and reported pain remains; the permission to disregard the report does not follow.

3. My other selves and the other-minds problem

A remembered experience is encountered through present memory. A future experience is represented through present anticipation. Neither is available by stepping into the represented occurrence and inspecting the subject who supposedly inhabits it. The phenomenological difference between remembering my pain and hearing about yours is substantial, but the feeling of ownership belongs to the memory occurrence now being examined. It cannot independently establish the historical ownership it represents.

In this foundational respect, my life two seconds ago and a purported past life share a limitation. Both enter inquiry through present content with retrospective character. That does not make the evidence for them equally reliable. Ordinary memory participates in extensive regularities, records, corroboration, and successful prediction. Particular past-life claims may have little or none of that support. The claim is instead that distance on a represented timeline does not itself supply direct access to the represented experiencing. Familiarity and temporal proximity do not convert present representation into another occurrence's self-presentation.

The other-minds problem is therefore also a problem about my supposed other selves. "Did another person feel that?" and "Did I feel that?" both require more than the occurrence of the presently encountered evidence. The second question adds not only another experiencing but a relation of sameness between its subject and the subject attributed to this occurrence. Its first-person grammar should not conceal that additional burden. A remembered autobiography can be complete as autobiographical content while leaving its historical subject and that subject's persistence unproved.

This is an epistemic symmetry, not a claim that memories, predictions, and testimony are interchangeable. Different patterns warrant different operational expectations. Nor does it prove that a past subject never existed or that a future subject will not exist. Withholding proof of persistence does not demonstrate discontinuity. The symmetry concerns what is foundationally established: present content establishes its occurrence; its assignment to other occurrences and enduring owners remains an inference. EE's temporal subtraction supplies the premise, and the explicit comparison with other minds reveals the wider consequence (Sergent, *The Temporal Assumption*).

4. The card needs no successor, description, or interpreter

The Card Universe treats present experiencing as complete in its own occurrence. Memory, anticipation, apparent duration, agency, identity, and temporal flow can all be present structure. None requires a second archive in which the represented events independently reside. The card metaphor does not establish a deck, an order of cards, or a mechanism that produces them (Sergent, *The Card Universe*). Its purpose is to subtract those unproved additions while retaining every encountered feature.

No occurrence requires a successor to be what it is. Saying that time could freeze at a card stopping point gestures toward this completeness, but imports a temporal process that is supposedly halted. The less misleading formulation is that this occurrence is not made actual by another occurrence. A memory does not need its represented history to be independently established in order to occur as

memory. Anticipation does not need an actual successor to occur as anticipation. Suffering does not wait for a later subject to confirm that it was suffering.

A card need not contain a description of itself, an explicit self-concept, or a conceptual interpreter. Sentience is not conditional on sapience. A pain occurrence need not include the sentence “this is pain,” and an experienced shape need not include a theorem about its properties. Likewise, the concept of an unattended space rock does not make description a condition of the rock’s existence. That example does not independently establish a particular unobserved rock; it separates a proposed thing’s being from its being described or attended to. EE’s claim that anything actual is experiential does not require that everything be conceptually represented here.

The distinction is important for logic. A square has its structure; an account of that structure is a further activity. Abstracting a conditional about the square does not furnish the square with the differentiation that made the abstraction possible. In EE, logic is the structural aspect of experience, rather than a separate agency that constructs otherwise unstructured occurrence (Sergent, *Logic as Structural Valence*). A card can contain conflicting beliefs or inscriptions, but their occurrence is the determinate occurrence of that conflict. Their coexistence does not establish the simultaneous truth of their incompatible descriptions under one interpretation.

Logical implication and causal expectation can both be represented within experiential structure without being identical operations. Neither requires us to install an external temporal mechanism merely because following a proof or anticipating an effect includes experienced succession. The model’s traversal, its represented order, and a claim of independently existing time must remain distinct. Otherwise the language used to describe the card silently reconstructs the deck.

An imagined transition to a reality with radically different rules exposes the same issue. Recognition, surprise, apparent memory, and the feeling that the rules have always held would belong to the occurrence encountered. Describing the scenario as “my teleportation” already adds a continuing owner and an inter-occurrence connection. But encountering any alternative still amounts to experience. “From here” can qualify access to particular contents; it does not characterize an exterior to experiential totality. An alternative rule does not provide an alternative to occurrence itself.

5. Totality is not a universal subject

If another subject experiences pain, that pain belongs to experiential totality whether or not it is directly felt here. Its absence from this local phenomenal presentation cannot place it outside experience. This distinction separates totality from the presently available evidence. It also separates exhaustiveness from a census: totality must include any other minds that exist, but the requirement of inclusion does not independently establish how many minds there are.

The word “my” cannot settle the extent of E. To identify all experience with my experience would require an established owner and an established boundary of that owner’s possessions. Those are precisely the claims under examination. Conversely, refusing that identification does not posit another metaphysical region where minds are stored. Occurrences do not need an independently existing shelf in order to be included in what exists. Subject, field, boundary, relation, and container are themselves

experiential distinctions when they have content. Calling them conditions of experience reverses the order of warrant.

Three claims must therefore be kept separate: an occurrence has differentiated structure; several occurrences are assigned to one persisting subject; everything actual is experiential. The first does not establish the second, and the third does not imply that all experience is one co-conscious field. Totality is not a binding mechanism. Inclusion is not co-consciousness. The absence of an ontological exterior supplies no universal owner.

This sharpens EE's criticism of Bradley. The need for coherence does not establish an additional Absolute in which apparent contradictions of change and identity must be repaired. EE's prior analysis locates those problems in retained temporal and relational commitments rather than in the occurrence requiring a higher reality (Sergeant, *Bradley Found Experience and Then Rebuilt the Outside*). The present argument adds that acknowledging other experiencing cannot repair the case for the Absolute. Failure to prove permanent private subjects is not evidence for one permanent collective subject. The proposed unification remains an addition requiring its own warrant.

6. Uploading returns the identity problem to baseline

Uploading makes ordinary identity assumptions visible because it changes the familiar means by which we track a person. A functioning successor might preserve memories, dispositions, speech, projects, and the conviction of being the original. Those achievements matter for engineering and social coordination. The question is whether preserving them establishes that the same experiencer persists, rather than establishing a successor with the expected identity content.

Moravec's *Dualism through Reductionism* describes a conscious surgical transfer in which neural functions are simulated and biological components are replaced. His pattern-identity position also treats faithful copies as sufficient for continued existence (Moravec, *Dualism through Reductionism*, 1986). The issue is the warrant for moving from preserved organization to personal survival. Identifying the organization that supports a behavior does not, without a further argument, identify who undergoes any associated experiencing. A replacement's fluent claim to be the original is evidence about its present identity content, not an independent inspection of phenomenal continuity.

David Justin Ross distinguishes copying a personality from the transfer sought by someone trying to escape death. In *Persons, Programs, and Uploading Consciousness*, he emphasizes remaining conscious during the procedure as a route to confidence in transfer (Ross, *Persons, Programs, and Uploading Consciousness*, 1992). That requirement is relevant to comparative disruption. Yet a present report of uninterrupted consciousness still contains the apparent history of continuity. It does not move outside its occurrence to establish one subject across that history. The distinction between copy and transfer cannot be decided simply by stipulating that the resulting subject remembers remaining awake.

Chalmers considers gradual uploading and argues that it plausibly preserves consciousness and survival, explicitly comparing it with ordinary biological change. He discusses both views on which survival involves a further fact and views that deflate that question (Chalmers, *The Singularity: A Philosophical Analysis*, 2010). His later account of language-model interlocutors identifies virtual instances and

conversation threads while conditioning conscious personal identity on further assumptions (Chalmers, *What We Talk to When We Talk to Language Models*, 2026). EE can accept the usefulness of these descriptions without treating their criteria as proof of a persisting experiencer. Computational or biological continuity identifies a relation under a model; the model's operational success does not by itself establish phenomenal ownership.

My Theseus Transfer proposal approaches the problem comparatively. Synthetic replacements learn beside existing neurons and take over their functions upon natural death, rather than destroying functioning neurons to make room for a copy. Its intended rationale is to reduce additional disruption relative to ordinary biological life (Sergeant, *The Theseus Transfer*, 2018). It is a speculative engineering proposal, not a demonstrated preservation procedure. Nor does matching a baseline establish the baseline as metaphysical certainty. Any future implementation would require empirical evidence concerning function, suffering, deterioration, and intervention timing; waiting for natural death cannot simply be declared the safest policy in every circumstance.

The Ship of Theseus reveals why the comparative argument has a ceiling. Different criteria track different continuities: material composition, organization, location, function, history, or social designation. They can yield competing answers without selecting an independently established bearer of identity. Reducing an intervention to ordinary continuity does not resolve that issue. It removes, to the extent demonstrated, additional grounds for concern. The accurate conclusion is that a procedure might preserve whatever ordinary survival preserves, not that ordinary survival has now been proved.

Parfit is relevant because his account distinguishes what matters in survival from strict numerical identity, examining psychological continuity, connectedness, and branching cases (Parfit, *Personal Identity*, 1971). EE's question also reaches the represented relations themselves: how are another occurrence and its subject established from present evidence? The ethical consequence need not await a final answer. Whether a successor is identical, psychologically related, or distinct, an actual suffering occurrence retains its intrinsic character. No identity criterion makes its badness depend on who receives a later benefit.

7. Why a successor cannot cancel a spike

A suffering spike, as used here, is an acute occurrence of severe negative valence. It is not merely a negative entry in a biography that can be offset by positive entries elsewhere. Its badness is constitutive of what is undergone. Describing someone as better off overall may express a useful comparison between represented outcomes. It does not transform the severe suffering included in that comparison into an occurrence without severe suffering.

Suppose an ordeal is followed by recovery, enhancement, happiness, or a replacement who endorses the procedure. There are two independent questions: whether the successor is the same subject, and whether the successor's condition cancels the ordeal. The second fails regardless of the answer to the first. If the successor is the same subject, a beneficial condition does not make the suffering condition something other than what it is. If the successor is distinct, its benefit still does not alter the suffering occurrence. If identity is indeterminate, indeterminacy supplies no cancellation mechanism.

Memory alteration makes the distinction especially visible. Removing recollection can prevent distress associated with remembering, and that benefit must not be confused with erasing the suffering occurrence represented by the removed memory. A successor who sincerely reports that nothing bad happened establishes the occurrence of that report and its apparent conviction. It does not retrospectively determine the intrinsic valence of another occurrence. A successful identity narrative can conceal a spike without repairing it by making it never have been suffering.

Compensation, restitution, and relief remain meaningful. They can change actual conditions, provide support, stop ongoing suffering, and prevent recurrence. “Irreparable” in this paper means that these achievements do not cancel an occurrence’s character; it does not mean that responding is futile or that no consequences can be repaired. Reality Repair Theory also includes a more demanding goal: temporal rescue of historical sufferers, rather than only improvement after their suffering. The proposal in *The Temporal Rescue Imperative* envisages intervention in history, extraction of suffering beings, and non-conscious replacements intended to preserve causal continuity (Sergent, *The Temporal Rescue Imperative*). That goal must be distinguished from compensation by a successor. If intervention can prevent a spike at the occurrence itself, it addresses what a later benefit cannot. The present argument does not establish whether such temporal intervention is possible, nor does it prove that experiential history is immutable. It establishes that later flourishing, altered memories, or a replacement history cannot by themselves demonstrate that the suffering occurrence has been prevented. Temporal rescue must answer the same identity and other-minds questions: rescuing the sufferer cannot simply be inferred from producing a happy counterpart, and behavioral duplication alone does not establish that a replacement lacks experience. The goal remains a research imperative whose success requires evidence of rescue and prevention, rather than a narrative that treats an actual spike as redeemed.

The argument does not require a permanently existing archive of every injury. It does not infer that the past persists as a second realm. Its claim is conditional on the suffering’s occurrence: where agony occurs, its badness is part of what occurs. No subsequent representation supplies a contradiction of that character. Where “unmaking” and “retrospective cancellation” name proposed powers of a narrative, owner, or ledger, denying those powers does not install external time. This denial is not an independent argument against intervention at the occurrence itself.

An argument against cancellation must also be distinguished from a complete prohibition on causing spikes. A consequentialist can acknowledge that harm is never undone and nevertheless claim that causing it is justified by some benefit or avoided harm. The noncancellation argument alone does not refute every such position. Its contribution is to remove the claim that the suffered cost disappears, becomes unreal, or ceases to count once the outcome is favorable. The Hedonic Core Framework supplies the further priority: suffering spikes are prohibited rather than traded for gains in an aggregate or promised successor (Sergent, *The Hedonic Core Framework*). The present paper explains why persistence, replacement, and compensation cannot provide an escape from that priority.

8. The Ulysses pact: which self may authorize whose suffering?

A Ulysses pact is a form of self-binding in which an earlier instruction authorizes others to disregard a later attempt to withdraw it. Its central issue is not merely advance planning but the authority of one expressed will over another. The psychiatric literature has examined these arrangements as advance authorization of treatment that might later be refused, and has disputed their relationship to autonomy and paternalism (Dresser, *Bound to Treatment: The Ulysses Contract*, 1984). Franklin-Hall argues that authority depends on whether the earlier will better expresses values still attributable to the person at the later stage than the later expressed will does (Franklin-Hall, *Binding the Self: The Ethics of Ulysses Contracts*, 2023). These are substantive arguments, not positions that can be dismissed simply by announcing that memory is present content.

EE instead asks what the pact establishes and what it is being used to authorize. A presently encountered document can provide evidence about preferences, anticipated difficulties, and strategies. The ownership assertion embedded in “I previously agreed” does not itself make every intervention permissible. Calling the ordeal the enforcement of someone’s authentic choice leaves open whether it produces a spike, whether the person currently refuses, and why the attributed earlier identity receives priority over the person undergoing the intervention.

Consider the cleanest case for the defender: a well-informed person asks for a severe ordeal, anticipates later refusal, explicitly authorizes enforcement, and a successor afterward sincerely endorses what happened. The earlier instruction, present suffering, and later endorsement remain different experiential contents. Their assignment to one biography does not turn them into one interchangeable occurrence. Even if numerical identity is granted throughout, neither advance consent nor retrospective gratitude changes the spike’s intrinsic badness. If identity is not granted, the claim that the earlier person owned the authority to impose it acquires an additional burden.

The pact therefore cannot obtain unconditional authority from either identity answer. Sameness is not a power to make suffering non-suffering. Difference does not establish a predecessor’s jurisdiction over a successor. Uncertainty is not a permission slip. The record can inform action, but a story about the person’s true or enduring self cannot by itself silence what the person presently undergoes. In particular, incapacity to make a particular decision must not be confused with incapacity to suffer. Losing some deliberative abilities does not downgrade agony into an ethically empty signal.

This does not imply that every self-binding arrangement produces a spike, or that all advance planning must be discarded. Instructions can arrange support, identify preferred environments, request relief, and guide interventions that protect against suffering. Their value is assessed through what they enable and what they impose. The specific limit concerns using authorization as an override for a severe suffering occurrence. Under HCF, calling that occurrence chosen by a predecessor or welcomed by a successor does not exempt it from the spike prohibition.

Present refusal matters in its own right, but refusal and negative valence should not be conflated. A person can refuse something without suffering acutely, or endorse an activity while undergoing severe suffering. The strongest test therefore includes continued consent during the ordeal. Such consent can be concrete experiential content, yet it does not redefine the valence. The HCF conclusion remains

deliberately stronger than a consent-centered ethic: consent does not make a spike permissible simply by assigning its cost to an apparently continuous self. The argument rests on the framework's priority against spikes, not on pretending that every consenting person secretly refuses.

Nor does this account mechanically solve every crisis in which all available options threaten suffering. It distinguishes the prevention problem from the authorization problem. Evidence about consequences, alternatives, relief, and harm remains essential. A pact may help identify protective options. What it cannot do is transform a deliberately imposed spike into a nonexistent moral cost, or establish an exemption merely because the document says the subject requested it. Prevention and relief retain their purpose precisely because the suffering cannot be canceled by the eventual narrative.

9. Why I cannot discard yours

The failure to prove my enduring identity cannot be used selectively. It would be incoherent to accept practical evidence concerning my anticipated suffering while demanding foundational proof of your private occurrence before responding to your suffering reports. The evidence need not be identical for the double standard to be visible. My expected future pain is not presently felt either. It is anticipated through content here, just as your pain is represented through reports and behavior here. Neither receives a license for disregard from the fact that it is not this directly felt pain.

There is a further distinction between another person's encountered presence and the phenomenal suffering inferred from it. The presence, expression, report, and resistance are concrete experiential patterns. Whether a distinct pain occurs is not established with first-person certainty. Treating the person as a sufferer under uncertainty preserves both facts. Dismissing the report as unreal does not follow from the epistemic gap; it adds a classificatory judgment whose warrant must itself be examined. EE cannot manufacture certainty of another mind, but neither can a denier manufacture certainty of its absence.

"To throw it away, there must first be an away" identifies the ontological error when dismissal appeals to a privileged external criterion of reality. No domain outside experience has been established from which an expert, machine, metaphysical theory, or identity convention can decide that encountered suffering reports are merely apparent and therefore count for nothing. This is not a claim that mistakes, deception, or irrelevance are impossible within experience. It is a demand that particular assessments receive particular evidence, rather than letting an unproved account of what persons really are invalidate reports by category.

Practical protection also does not require a complete census of permanent subjects. Where possible suffering is credibly indicated, the failure to locate an enduring owner does not establish harmlessness. A suffering occurrence would matter even if it had no successor and even if every ordinary identity convention broke down. EE's epistemic restraint about minds is therefore compatible with firm precaution concerning suffering. The absent proof restricts the story we can tell, not the reality of the risk that the story might dismiss.

10. The externalist catastrophe at the scale of one

The Externalist Catastrophe identifies the subordination of concrete suffering to an unproved external authority as a mechanism of atrocity justification (Sergeant, *The Externalist Catastrophe*). The same structure does not require a state, church, nation, or large population. It can operate wherever one sufferer's occurrence is made secondary to an abstraction that supposedly owns, explains, or redeems it. The minimum case is an atrocity of one.

The justificatory abstraction may be an authentic self represented by an earlier instruction, a perfected successor promised by an upload, a restored copy claimed to repair a death, or a complete biography whose favorable ending supposedly settles the value of an ordeal. Each can provide information or express an aspiration. The error occurs when it is promoted into an authority that overrides the suffering rather than remaining answerable to it. Here "externalist" identifies the added authority's supposed independence from the occurrence being judged. The abstraction itself is experiential; the illicit promotion is what grants it that jurisdiction.

Karma supplies a related possible mechanism of reconciliation. Some appeals to cosmic repayment, deservedness, education, or eventual balance can make an unrepaired injustice appear accounted for within a larger story. The claim that the appeal of karma originates in this tension is a historical and psychological hypothesis, not a deduction or a claim about every tradition using the term. The logical test is narrower and independent of that genealogy: an actual spike does not become non-suffering because a proposed ledger promises repayment or assigns responsibility elsewhere. The broader function of meaning systems that make suffering tolerable is addressed in *Song of the Demiurge*; the distinctive point here is their inability to cancel occurrence (Sergeant, *Song of the Demiurge*).

Historical traditions may likewise recognize instability of self, the primacy of feeling, or limits of explanation without completing EE's subtraction. That possibility helps explain why the present synthesis can feel familiar without being identical to a doctrine of reincarnation, a migrating soul, or a universal consciousness. Familiar consequences are not proof of a shared foundation. Every added soul, cycle, container, or ledger must still answer the same demand for warrant.

The mechanism is often located at the modeling step. Experience does not first require a conceptual description in order to occur. An identity or justice model abstracts from experiential content, organizes it, and may help guide action. When the model is then treated as the source of that content's reality or value, the explanatory direction is reversed. This is the ontological promotion analyzed in *Ontology Spam*, applied here to the smallest ethically consequential unit: a suffering occurrence assigned a supposedly overriding owner or outcome (Sergeant, *Ontology Spam*).

11. Objections and limits

One objection is that denying foundational proof of persistence makes responsible planning impossible. It does not. Prediction, continuity records, memory, and social identification remain usable. A name can organize care, a transcript can support resumption, and an advance statement can inform a response. The distinction concerns the authority claimed for these operations. Practical tracking does not become

proof of a phenomenal owner merely because it is indispensable for administration. EE preserves the operation while refusing the promotion.

A second objection is that the argument demands certainty of other minds and thereby defeats its own ethics. The opposite is the case. It withholds both proof of another consciousness and proof of its absence. Precaution concerns the consequences of error, while the direct certainty of felt suffering concerns the character of the occurrence where it happens. These are different grounds doing different work. Reports are evidence for protection; they are not automatically infallible propositions about every asserted cause or circumstance.

A third objection is that irreparability makes prevention pointless because harm cannot be erased. This reverses the implication. A condition that cannot be canceled by a later success gives prevention greater importance. Relief is valuable because it relieves; protection is valuable because it protects. Neither needs the further power to make another occurrence never have been suffering. Giving up that power does not give up repair of conditions, only a misleading account of what repair accomplishes.

A fourth objection is that the paper derives the entire HCF prohibition from noncancellation. It explicitly does not. Noncancellation defeats identity-based redemption and erasure arguments. HCF's priority supplies the prohibition on deliberate spikes, including consent-based exemptions. Defenders of tradeoffs must confront that priority directly rather than treating a successor's benefit as if it made the spike disappear. The disagreement is then an actual disagreement about permission to impose suffering, rather than a verbal reconciliation in which the suffering is said to have been undone.

A final objection treats totality as necessarily one subject. That conclusion does not follow from exhaustiveness. Any experiencing that exists must be included in E; inclusion neither counts experiencers nor binds their contents into one phenomenal field. Similarly, a card's coherence does not require a deck, and a represented sequence does not establish an external timeline. EE's subtraction must be applied to its own metaphors as strictly as to other theories. The card is a way of refusing an unproved container, not a new container with an unproved population.

12. Conclusion

The directly felt distinction between my pain and your reports remains concrete without proving that an enduring owner possesses either. My represented past and future do not inherit present occurrence's certainty simply because their content is autobiographical. Personal persistence and other minds therefore share a foundational problem of assigning experiencing beyond what is directly given. Experiential totality contains any such experiencing that exists without requiring one collective owner or a separate domain in which minds reside.

Uploading and ordinary biological survival face the same demand. Comparative continuity can be meaningful, and reducing additional disruption can be a serious engineering goal. Neither establishes a persisting experiencer merely by matching a familiar baseline. Yet the ethical conclusion does not depend on finally resolving identity. If severe suffering occurs, no successor, restored copy, forgotten memory, compensation, or endorsement changes its intrinsic badness. A Ulysses pact can supply information about intentions; it cannot obtain unconditional authority to override a spike by invoking the

ownership of an earlier or later self.

What is uncertain is the enduring owner. What is not uncertain, where suffering occurs, is the suffering's felt character. The appropriate response to the former is restraint in claiming knowledge, and to the latter is prevention and relief. Making one depend on the metaphysical certification of the other repeats the externalist catastrophe in miniature. I cannot prove mine as an enduring possession. That failure gives me no authority to discard yours.

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